Metal-Revetted Door

From the mosque of Sultan al-Mu`ayyad Shaykh

Burji Mamluk, 818-24 AH / 1415-21 CE

Wood and Brass or Bronze

W: 120 cm; H: 345 cm

Hall 1

Inv. no. 1065



The front façade of the door © NADIM Foundation

The Circassian Mamluks introduced a distinctive form of door ornamentation featuring a metal fitting, usually made of bronze, placed at the centre of the door and known as a bukhariyya or anṣa. Its design was inspired by motifs found in various illuminated manuscripts. These fittings reflect a combination of exceptional craftsmanship, a deep understanding of the technical and creative demands of the craft,

and a refined aesthetic sensibility, evident in the careful balance of the door's overall composition and its decorative elements.

The bukhariyya also responded to the need for austerity adopted by most Circassian Mamluk sultans following the loss of the spice trade from India to the Venetians and Florentines. This selection presents a range of bukhariyya designs, from the earliest examples on the doors of the courtyard of Sultan Barquq's Mosque on Al-Muʿizz Street to the door of Qaytbay in the Qarafa cemetery, including the door of Sultan al-Muʾayyad Shaykh, displayed before you.

Museum records note that this door was recovered from the mosque of Sultan al-Muʾayyad Shaykh (818-24 AH / 1415-21 CE). Yet during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the building served as a repository and conservation workshop for architectural salvage from across Historic Cairo. Was the door commissioned for the site, or did it arrive from elsewhere? A clue may resolve the question: a fragmentary naskh inscription preserves a prayer invoking "survival, elation, and ascension", a standard supplication linked to the sultan by his contemporary al-Qalqashandi (756-821 AH / 1355-1418 CE). This textual evidence suggests the door was likely original to the mosque itself, not a later arrival. Traces of its former metal revetment survive in the central bukhariyya medallion, faint remnants of a once-gleaming surface that would have commanded attention within the sultan's architectural complex.

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